Save Tompkins Square Park

The community endorses NYC Parks' original Option 3

What is NYC Parks proposing?

On Oct 15, NYC Parks presented three options to CB3 for rebuilding and expanding the kids' pool at East 10th Street and Avenue B, and argued for Option 1. That option would demolish and rebuild the courts, the bars and nearby areas, closing everything for 18 months or more. On Oct 27, the full Community Board 3 sent the plan back to its Parks Committee, which takes it up again on Nov 12.

What are we asking CB3 to do?

Vote for Option 3, which Parks already offered:

- Rebuild the pool.
- Build the stormwater tanks in a way that minimizes disruption to the basketball courts, and allows future maintenance without closing them again.
- Preserve the existing workout equipment. Any proposed enhancements should be non-intrusive and supported by credible research.

We also ask that board members visit the bars, feel the equipment, and watch how people of all ages, races, genders and athletic abilities use them. You will understand why we love them and the community they nourish.

Did the community ask for this?

No. More than 3,500 people have signed a petition asking Parks not to demolish and rebuild the courts, the bars and adjacent areas, because they are not broken.

Are you against a bigger pool for kids?

No. Build a better pool.

Aren't the bars old and in bad shape?

They are nearly 40 years old and remain solid. Parks admits their "structural integrity has not been determined." Its own records agree they are sound.

Could the bars be repaired?

Yes. And that's what Parks used to do. It painted the bars in 2019, replaced the safety surface in 2024, and welded the bars when they lost a bolt. Repairing is cheaper, faster, and greener than demolition.

Don't the bars have to be made accessible?

The experts we consulted are adamant that the bars are already accessible. People of every age, size and ability use them, including for rehab after injury. The equipment has wide clearance all around, including wheelchair-compatible clearance. Parks claims the surface route is inaccessible, but it installed a new surface two years ago, and its own inspectors have long called that spot "accessible" in internal records. Which accessibility requirement does the installation fail, and can it be fixed without replacing the bars?

Shouldn't the equipment be ADA certified?

There is no such thing. The ADA establishes design standards for an area as a whole, and does not approve or certify equipment. An “ADA compliant” seal on a product is a manufacturer’s marketing claim.

Aren't the bars in violation of “city code”?

Parks said so, but its own report clarifies that these standards (ASTM F3101) are private, optional and voluntary, with the exception of “Lack of ADA accessible route,” which Parks remedied two years ago.

What about the drainage pipes?

Parks mentioned this briefly but did not share its findings. Under Option 3, Parks itself proposed running a new drain line beside the bars, “minimally disrupting the existing fitness.”

Won't Parks build it back new and better?

New is not better. Parks’ own records on new equipment elsewhere are quite damning. These bars are known around the world, and tourists come to the East Village to see them. Parks has promised it will try to reproduce the layout of the existing equipment to allow for the full range of current uses. The law, however, constrains Parks along multiple dimensions on what it can buy or build. This means it cannot say with confidence what will happen.

Aren't Parks officials the experts?

Parks' track record on workout equipment is weak. At 40 of 64 other parks with fitness areas, its own records show serious, chronic or premature problems. The pull-up bars it installed in Chelsea were unstable from day one. At Hamilton Fish Park, the redesigned bars remain “sparsely used,” as the New York Times reported. We visited Macombs Dam Park, where the bars were rebuilt in 2020. We saw vestiges of bars that have already fallen apart, and saw how the remaining ones shake during regular use.

Why do the basketball courts have to close?

The courts were rebuilt in 2015 and repainted two years ago. Many players consider them the city's best. They are in the crosshairs because Parks wants to put stormwater tanks in the center of the area. Parks officials say tanks tend to go under basketball courts. Public records show only 34 of 335 do, about one in ten. Tanks might need maintenance, so the courts would close again every time they are serviced. What viable alternatives has Parks explored to minimize disruption to players?

Isn't a brand new park worth 18 months?

Eighteen months is a long time, and it might take longer. East River Park's outdoor gym is closed through 2027. The cheapest gym nearby costs $500 a year and does not allow kids. The YMCA is about $1,200 for one adult. Where should the kids go? Where should adults go if they dislike private gyms or can’t afford one? Why close down a hub that is so important for the community?

Who are we?

We are a diverse set of park users and neighbors of Tompkins Square Park. To support us, sign the petition, email public leaders, and follow @save.tompkins. Write to us at savetsp@gmail.com.